

Murder on the Beach

Farrukh Dhondy's thriller, stretching from Paris to Goa, is inspired by Charles Sobhraj

By Bunny Suraiya

As the book's title suggests, this is a thinly-veiled biography of Charles Sobhraj, the serial killer who was given the soubriquet 'Bikini Murderer' by an American journalist in Thailand way back at the start of his infamous career, when he was accused of killing young women, mainly backpacking tourists, who flocked to the beaches of Thailand.

Like Sobhraj, the protagonist—one can hardly call him a hero—Edward du Monde (the last name is an intriguing touch, connoting 'of the World'; does the author see him as a sort of Everyman?), is born in French-occupied Saigon to a Vietnamese mother who is little better than a whore, and an Indian father who is into a host of fraudulent activities, including dealing in misbegotten currency and gems.

Du Monde's career faithfully follows that of Sobhraj, from his stint as a juvenile prisoner in Paris (nabbed for robbery) and the earliest Bangkok killings, to his poisoning of a coach of French tourists in India, which led to his incarceration in Delhi's Tihar jail where bribery enabled him to live a life of luxury before his sensational escape.

Du Monde's recapture in a Goan restaurant replicates the events that occurred in O' Coqueiro, near Panjim, where to this day a statue of Sobhraj sits at a front table for the world to see.

Dhondy subscribes to the convincing theory, that both the escape and subsequent recapture were ploys masterminded by the killer in order to extend his jail sentence in India and so avert extradition to Thailand where he would have faced a firing squad. Sobhraj, like his fictive counterpart, made sure that by the time he was released from Tihar, 20 years later, the statute of limitations on his crimes in Thailand had run out.

Again, like Sobhraj, du Monde becomes a Parisian celebrity and amasses a large fortune before an error of judgement—perhaps the only one—takes him back to Kathmandu where a policeman with an incorruptible nature and a phenomenal memory captures him for a murder committed in Nepal 28 years before.



THE BIKINI MURDERS
by FARRUKH DHONDY
HarperCollins India
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 272

With so many correspondences between Sobhraj and du Monde, the question that teases the reader's mind is: why didn't Dhondy write an authentic biography of his subject? Why did he fictionalise it? After all, Sobhraj is very accessible in his prison cell in Kathmandu, and by all accounts, a great raconteur who enjoys giving interviews about his perverted talents.

The answer comes in virtually the last pages, and the final kicker in the last paragraph is one that knocks your socks off. It's worth every page of the rest of the book, repetitive though the tale can get due to the unvarying nature of the killer's modus operandi (befriending, poisoning, dumping the body), because even if you're the kind who can't resist peeking at the end, you won't make sense of it without reading what went before.

Just hang in there. You'll be rewarded. Guaranteed.



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